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"By Any Means Necessary": Corporate Capitalism and Pathological Narcissism in Gary Shteyngart's Fiction

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ABSTRACT
Ranked as a liberal globalist writer in Caren Irr's overview of the canon of US fiction today, the literary output of contemporary American writer Gary Shteyngart (*Absurdistan*, 2006; *Super Sad True Love Story*, 2010; *Lake Success*, 2018; *Our Country Friends*, 2021), which involves diverse narrative, stylistic and genre conventions, shares an overarching theme that runs through all these texts: all four novels foreground the narcissistic nature of the wealthy, directly inscribing these traits within the dominant and inescapable paradigm of globalisation and late capitalism within and beyond America. In these novels, such narcissism often reaches pathological extremes, as it can become the main driving force in a character's portrayal. To date, this thread has not been pursued in depth across Shteyngart's oeuvre. This article examines the entrepreneurs and achievers in these four novels as embodying various forms of (sometimes pathological) narcissism that relate to and draw from the conditions of corporate capitalism and digital era technologies, in the light of recent theories by sociologists, political scientists, philosophers and cultural critics who have examined how the contemporary human condition is impacted by the forces of globalisation in its numerous ramifications.

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A distinctive voice in twenty-first century American literature, Gary Shteyngart's fictional output over the past two decades has provided, often with acerbic wit, a very relevant critique on the forces of globalisation and the enduring, pervasive influence of American cultural values across the world. Ranked as a "liberal globalist" writer in Caren Irr's overview of the canon of US fiction today,[1] his fiction has evolved from the early, partly droll, assimilation narratives foregrounding Russian and Soviet legacies (*The Russian Debutante's Handbook*, 2002 and *Absurdistan*, 2006) to the "situated" contemporary American novel, engaging a dystopian genre in *Super Sad True Love Story* (2010) and realist modes in *Lake Success* (2018) and the pandemic novel *Our Country Friends* (2021). Critics and readers alike have noted the writer's use of wealthy protagonists, such as Misha Vainberg in *Absurdistan* and Barry Cohen in *Lake Success*, while other novels feature characters who profit from – or fall prey to – the forces of neoliberal techno-capitalism: Joshie Goldman and Lenny Abramov in *Super Sad True Love Story*. In

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[1]Caren Irr, *Toward the Geopolitical Novel*, 21.

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Our Country Friends, a novel set against the background of the Covid-19 pandemic, most of the characters who self-isolate in Sasha Senderovsky's estate in upstate New York are expressive of wealth or material success. Allowing for their diverse story lines, thematic scope, or satirical intent, a common thread runs through these texts: all four novels foreground pathologically narcissistic characters, whose motivations and actions are enabled through the dominant neoliberal paradigm of corporate capitalism and the digital-era technologies involved in this global economic system.

1. Narcissism, Neoliberalism, Technocapitalism: The Contemporary Sites of Shteyngart's Achievers

While the shape-shifting notions of the American Dream, in their evolution (or devaluation) from ideals of social climbing, financial autonomy and personal freedom towards now prevalent forms of materialism and consumerism is by now a hackneyed topic, the ways in which the globalised, fast-travelling, hyperconnected contemporary era has contributed to reshape these notions towards blatant forms of narcissism is of particular relevance in examining the kinds of characters that populate Shteyngart's fiction, often with a satirical intent. As noted above, this is a writer whose fiction recurrently includes affluent protagonists (or antagonists) whose mindsets embody the contemporary admiration for the power of wealth. Writing at the turn of the millennium, Zygmunt Bauman, drawing from Jeremy Seabrook's arguments that world-wide poverty and inequality are intrinsic to the operation of global capitalism[2] and how present-day societies rely on "the development of an artificially created and subjective sense of insufficiency", highlights the cultural shift from the admiration of the work-ethic (the "self-made" exemplar) towards the veneration of wealth itself:[3]

> It is *what one can do* that matters, not *what is to be done* or *what has been done*. Universally adored in ... the rich is their wondrous ability to pick and choose the contents of their lives, places to live in now and then, partners to share those places with – and to change all of them at will and without effort. The fact that they seem never to reach points of no return, [or limit] to their reincarnations, that their future looks forever richer in content and more enticing than their past; last but not least, that the only thing which seems to matter to them is the range of prospects their wealth seems to throw open.[4]

At a surprisingly rapid pace, technological developments over the first quarter of the twenty-first century have tended to exacerbate the drives towards wealth through the boundless, unrestrained, and deregulated practices of technocapitalism, which has been recognised by sociologists, philosophers and cultural critics as a radical, destabilising element in the contemporary conceptualisations of individual freedoms, citizenship and the welfare state, and democratic governance.[5] Such drives towards wealth aided by technocapitalist channels have found their ideal breeding ground in the transformation of the modern American consciousness from individualism to narcissism. Writing in

[2]In other words, eradicating global poverty is only possible by abandoning capitalism as an economic system (Jeremy Seabrook, *The Race for Riches*).
[3]Although it is not my aim to diverge into political discussion, Donald Trump's reelection is symptomatic of Bauman's visionary notion, as the intensification of this cultural shift has permeated American politics.
[4]Bauman, "Tourists and Vagabonds," 94–5, in *Globalization: The Human Consequences*.
[5]See Beck, *World at Risk*, 110; Bauman, *Liquid Times*, 75; Han, *Psychopolitics*, 1–15, among others.

1979, decades before the world wide web appeared, Christopher Lasch cross-examined various facets of American life (social interactions, business relations, sports and games, sexual behaviours, family life) in *The Culture of Narcissism* to examine the prevalence of "pathological narcissism"[6] as follows:

> the psychological patterns associated with pathological narcissism, which in less exaggerated form manifest themselves [...] in the fascination with fame and celebrity, the fear of competition, the inability to suspend disbelief, the shallowness and transitory quality of personal relations, the horror of death, originate in the peculiar structure of the American family, which ... originates in changing modes of production.[7]

Significantly, Lasch's vision of the transformation of American values in the sixties and seventies has now become relevant, to an unprecedented degree, to contemporary American youth culture in the era of technocapitalism. A number of commentators have noted the collusion of capitalist principles, narcissistic trends and the networking potential of the world wide web. Particularly relevant in this context are Byung Chul-Han arguments, developed in his *The Transparency Society* (2015), regarding how neoliberalism promotes narcissism through social networks engineered to lure users towards creations of commodified, "likeable", "popular", versions of the self. As I will be arguing in the following pages, Gary Shteyngart's fiction, across the four novels *Absurdistan*, *Super Sad True Love Story*, *Lake Success* and *Our Country Friends* is populated by achiever characters who, in several ways, and to diverse degrees, embody Bauman's notion of the "rich tourist" and the pathological narcissist diagnosed by Lasch, now shaped by the current conditions of a techno-neoliberal era of global capitalism that further enables their actions and behaviours.[8] With the exception of Karen Cho in *Our Country Friends*, these characters are always male and largely serve as the writer's conduits for his very relevant critiques of the contemporary American and global moods.

2. Contemporary Gatsbies: *Absurdistan* and *Lake Success*

The protagonists of *Absurdistan* and *Lake Success*, Misha Vainberg and Barry Cohen, essentially embody two visions of global wealth, which, in different, but related, ways, hark back to Fitzgerald's classic *The Great Gatsby* (1925). Like Jay Gatsby, they both share the quest for a "new life", or "starting over" inspired by a romantic interest. Also like Gatsby, but now within the coordinates of the late-capitalist global world, their extreme wealth originates either in the overtly corrupt world of Russian and international mafias (Misha) or in the dubious financial practices of asset management and hedge fund markets (Barry), such as precipitated the global financial crisis in 2007–08.

Adopting the episodic form of the picaresque genre, *Absurdistan* takes the perspective of Misha Vainberg, aka "Snack Daddy", a 30 year-old overweight Jewish Russian, and

[6]The term's original meaning is clinical, and comes from Freud's psychoanalitical school, which differentiated the primary (typical) narcissistic phase of the child's development, from narcissism as a persisting, or "pathological" condition, in youth and into adulthood, defined by traits such as a sense of entitlement and self-importance, belief in success fantasies (of power, riches, beauty, ideal love), lack of empathy and instrumentalisation of others, and a craving for admiration (see Peter Fonagy, *Freud's "On Narcissism: An Introduction"*).

[7]Lasch, *The Culture of Narcissism*, 176.

[8]Some critical approaches have engaged with the conceptualisation of individual Shteyngart characters vis-à-vis the American success ethic (see Bryla, "Rewriting the American Dream," 145–63; Ross Bullen, "Act Two for America," 231–53), but there is no extensive reading of the writer's fictional output from the angle proposed here.

billionaire son of a renown gangster who has been recently murdered by the Russian mafia. Misha has been aptly described by critic Steven Lee as "exemplifying [Slavoj] Žižek's free-floating global elite, asserting progressive superiority through a fetish for rap music and brown women".[9] The novel's plot involves Misha's circuituous quest to return to the US – where he has graduated in "Multiculturalism" at a midwestern "Accidental College" – to live in the South Bronx with his earthy, largely uneducated, African-American girlfriend. His entry visa has been denied repeatedly by the US State Department, as a result of his late father's involvement in the murder of an American businessman. A single child, Misha largely inhabits his "Beloved Papa's" legacy in Eastern Europe, which gives him access to unlimited funds, opens many connections with corrupt individuals, but also shapes his fate in unexpected ways.

As the novel's title proposes,[10] Shteyngart's parody is centrally aimed at both the constructedness of national identities and the interference of global capitalism in the evolution of their cultural configuration. Opening with Misha's frustration with post-Soviet Russia – "our St. Leninsburg [seems] a phantasmagoric third-world city … our intelligent, depressive citizenry … replaced by a new race of mutants, dressed in studied imitation of the West"[11] – the protagonist's return to the US involves securing a Belgian passport by bribing an official at the Embassy of the Republic of Absurdistan, and, having become a Belgian citizen, applying for an European Union visa.

As an early reviewer put it, "Shteyngart … thinks in peoples, not just individuals. He jokes in peoples, too, and not only about Jews and Russians, as his heritage entitles him to, but about … every other in-group he can outrage".[12] The novel parodies Russia, Belgium, and of course, Absurdistan, ostensibly defined by its oil reserves, as a thinly disguised caricature of Azerbaijan and its capital Baku:[13] "Absurdistan was the Caspian sea and the Caspian sea was the oil it held in abundance. The oil derricks began as soon as the last speck of humanity ended."[14] In Shteyngart's hyperbolic satire, Misha's act of purchasing Belgian identity in an oil-rich, corrupt, ex-Soviet republic in order to become European and thus be admitted in the US, bears out the arguments on the fading political relevancy of the nation-state put forth by Zygmunt Bauman and Slavoj Žižek, and its commodification at the service of contemporary global capitalism.[15] Such acts point at "the ultimate equivalence of Eastern organized crime with the routine, if better disguised, practices of Western capitalism".[16]

The Absurdi capital is divided between the Sevo quarter, home to "multinational skyscrapers, the embassies and the major retailers"[17] and the Svanï district, which looks like

[9]Lee, "Borat, Multiculturalism, 'Mnogonatsional'nost'," 31.
[10]Former Moscow bureau chief for *Newsweek* and *U.S News & World Report*, Christian Caryl recalls a friend there coining the term back in 1991: "a term for the everyday craziness. For him, the now-not-quite-Soviet Union was simply 'Absurdistan'" (Caryl, "The Birth of 'Absurdistan'").
[11]Shteyngart, *Absurdistan*, 45.
[12]Kirn, "Russian Unorthodox," Section 7 /1.
[13]Shteyngart had began work on the novel just before 9/11, after a sojourn in the Caucasus and middle East, but set it aside following the terrorist attacks. After further research in Baku in the summer of 2005, he resumed writing (Grinberg, "Can't Live Long").
[14]Shteyngart, *Absurdistan*, 134, 135.
[15]Bauman, *Globalization*, 68; Žižek, "Multiculturalism," 34. Dean Franco notes that all the characters "are so Žižekian as to make the theorist obsolete … they not only enjoy their symptoms, they also purchase their desire and can only have it in the act of consuming it" (178).
[16]Hamilton, *Understanding Gary Shteyngart*, 39.
[17]Shteyngart, *Absurdistan*, 132.

"Kabul … [with] aging men smoking cigarettes and gossiping around idled taxis."[18] Shteyngart's relentless satire underscores the surrender of nationhood and citizenship to global corporate interests. When an alleged civil war between Sevo and Svani ethnic groups breaks out, from the Hyatt Park Svani City hotel, Misha sees "tanks guard[ing] the strategically important Benetton store and the 718 Perfumery"[19] while "the American embassy was situated in the shadows of the Exxon-Mobil skyscraper".[20] Eventually, he discovers this civil war has actually been orchestrated by the ruling Sevo oligarchy, who, appealing to his narcissism, appoints him Minister of Multicultural Affairs, and has him draft a project for a "Caspian Holocaust Studies" institute.[21] In a final twist of the plot, Misha finds out there are no oil reserves left in Absurdistan, and that he has been instrumentalised by the Sevo oligarchs, effectively a gang of ex-KGB officials, in order to attract financial aid from Israel and the US for "post-war reconstruction", a perverse manoeuvre that evokes the alignment of the Bush administration with corporate interests during the invasion of Iraq in 2003. Shteyngart's satire turns bitter with Misha's final realisation that he has been a pawn in a geopolitical board game where any notion of national pride or cultural identity is a mere façade:

> So you destroy a country because it's not competitive. What kind of reason is that?
>
> It's the best reason, Misha. Nowadays, if you don't have natural resources you need USAID. You need the European Bank for Reconstruction and Development. … If only we could get on America's top-ten list and score big like Jordan or Egypt. Or Israel.[22]

This novel is, to date, the most extreme in Shteyngart's use of satire. As Dean Franco has noted, "*Absurdistan* leaves no part of culture, religion, or personal selfhood untouched by the corrupting hand of market commodification."[23] Centrally to my argument, the writer accomplishes this through the portrayal of a character whose wealth, body size and even surname – *Vain*-berg – symbolise the liberal American narcissistic belief in the potential of individual greatness to "change the world". Thus, throughout the novel, Misha embraces notions of "multiculturalism" and "humanitarianism", inspired by his Accidental College education (motto: "*Think one person can change the world? We do*."[24]) which are meaningless, impracticable or phony. In this respect, he is a forerunner in a line of narcissistic, often pathological, characters that people the writer's subsequent novels.

Lake Success (2018) is the second Shteyngart novel to shift its focus towards the domestic American scene, departing from the writer's usual narrative approach involving Russian cultural backgrounds. In the choice of protagonist and narrative agency, however, this work foregrounds, like *Absurdistan*, the narcissistic drives generated by late-stage capitalism and globalisation, also staging a peculiar variation of the American

[18]Ibid., 140.
[19]Ibid., 151.
[20]Ibid., 165.
[21]Shteyngart also aims his satire here at the commodification of Holocaust memorialising as a self-serving practice to appeal to financially influential Jewish lobbies.
[22]Shteyngart, *Absurdistan*, 311. The deliberate staging of the Svani-Sevo conflict in Absurdistan bears reading in the light of Ulrich Beck's articulation of the 'cosmopolitan moment' in world risk society as a double-edged notion, at once inspiring terror and creating room for action (Beck, *World at Risk*, 57).
[23]Franco, "Globalization's Complaint," 178.
[24]The motto was taken verbatim from Oberlin College, where the writer attended classes in the 1990s (Ibid., 178).

Dream that overtly invokes here the Gatsbian intertext.[25] The novel's opening lines, with the action *in medias res*, vividly invoke these notions:

> Barry Cohen, a man with 2.4 billion dollars of assets under management, staggered into the Port Authority Bus Terminal … drunk and bleeding. There was a clean slice above his left brow, where the nannie's fingernail had gouged him, and from his wife, a teardrop scratch below his eye.[26]

Immensely wealthy in the terms made possible only by global market capitalism (and its attendant abuses) and leading a lavish lifestyle in material terms, Barry has just blown his top over their autistic child, physically shaking him to try to make him talk. As the women intervene to protect the distressed child, on impulse, Barry Cohen leaves for the Greyhound bus terminal, recreating the trip he undertook 24 years earlier to visit a college girlfriend. Liliana Naydan has perceptively discussed this novel as illustrating a variety of modes of alienation, which function, via its protagonist, through a "relationship between social alienation and self-alienation"[27] that is symptomatic of American Republican identity in the context of the 2016 presidential election, where Trump became president. An early reviewer notes Barry's initial mood as expressive of the state of the nation: "his jittery mood parallels that of the country … envy and self-loathing exist side by side with a delusional love of an America that never really existed".[28] Although it is not my primary aim to discuss how *Lake Success* enacts American politics, these insights provide openings into the narcissism, solipsism and self-serving nature of the American corporate elites Barry embodies[29] and which this road novel develops through his Greyhound bus journey.

During the social dinner that precedes his night-time flight, he has felt deeply humiliated by his wife Seema's remark that "people in finance have no imagination. They have no soul".[30] His ensuing quest for discovery (and self-discovery) within this real America, romanticised in the Kerouacian / Hemingwayesque mode of seeking "real experience", bears out her diagnosis, as Barry is inevitably limited by his social background as a white wealthy "Wall Street guy,"[31] and his individual psycho-emotional shortcomings in "reading" the country and its peoples. Yet the quest itself is weirdly inauthentic, as he takes six luxury watches from his collection, and only later in the journey does he dump his "black Amex" credit card to avoid being tracked by his office. Barry's Greyhound experience provides several potential epiphanies for the ex-hedge fund manager, which he systematically fails to read. After a brief sexual encounter with a black woman he meets on the bus, he awakes in their hotel room in a panic believing she has stolen his six prized watches, only to discover an impeccably written, heartfelt note and the watches wisely stored (by her) in the hotel safe: "He read it again and again. It was a stupid thing to notice, but her punctuation was perfect, commas and

[25]See Bryla, "Rewriting the American Dream," 147–8 and Naydan, "Politics of Genre Migration," 363.
[26]Shteyngart, *Lake*, 3.
[27]Naydan, "Politics of Genre Migration," 364.
[28]Theroux, "America's New Age of Discontent."
[29]Liliana Naydan reads Fitzgerald's character Amory Blaine, in *This Side of Paradise*, as an archetype for Barry: "like Barry, Amory attends Princeton University, dabbles in writing, and feels alienated from an enriching life" (Naydan, "Politics of Genre Migration," 363). Shteyngart makes Barry's respect for Fitzgerald explicit in Barry's naming of his two hedge-funds "This Side of Capital" and "Last Tycoon Capital" (Shteyngart, *Lake* 66, 299).
[30]Shteyngart, *Lake*, 27.
[31]Ibid., 195.

all. He had portfolio managers who couldn't type a fucking email."[32] Running out of cash, he is accommodated by his ex-employee and late friend Jeff Parks, whom he had fired in his earlier life, and who even loans him cash to continue the journey. Parks quotes to him Willy Loman's wife classic appeal to compassion in Arthur Miller's *Death of a Salesman* ("Attention must be paid … "[33]), and goes on to try to make him see the impact of their global finances on the real world:

> But that's how I think of people like you. I always have the same visualisation. I start with a row of middle class houses like the one my dad lives in. And then I see you. You go from house to house, from family to family. And you take money from their wallets, from their purses, from under their sofa cushions, and you put it in your pockets, and when your pockets are full, you put it in a duffel bag with the logo of your fund. You don't sneak in. You don't break him. You just walk among these people as if they're invisible and you take the money they've earned. And then you go home and you buy a watch or whatever.[34]

Although his perceptions of the towns he walks through and discovers – Baltimore, Jackson, El Paso – are always coloured by neighboorhoods where urban social decay, crime, and economic stagnation become notorious, Barry never grasps his ex-employee's claim about the investor class' accountability in the decline of this "real America" he now sees for himself. When he finally reaches his college girlfriend Layla, now a single mother with a nerdy, introvert son, Barry takes it upon himself to befriend and act as surrogate father to the boy in these terms: "He would approach this kid as if he were a potential investor. He would seek out a commonality."[35] As Martyna Bryla has noted, Barry addresses others as if they need to benefit from his counsel, yet he is unable to grasp the human consequences of the predatory capitalism he has practiced, "invariably adopt[-ing] the position of a tutor who, using his motivational talk, promises to improve [people he meets] with the help of his financial assets and business know-how".[36] Significantly, for all his past successes attracting investors and managing funds, Barry has always felt vulnerable about socialising, to the point of rehearsing what he calls "friend moves". As Naydan notes, he displays "neurodiverse characteristics [such as] practicing lines in the mirror of his childhood home in order to regulate his social interactions", a social behaviour which, in its emotional inadequacy, is an autistic attribute.[37] One of the novel's ironies is that Barry lacks the self-knowledge to realise his likeness to his son Shiva: "The couples' therapist … had suggested that [as] a sign of Barry's own diagnosis. He actually kept a log of the seconds each watch … lost and gained … How was *that* not on the spectrum?"[38]

Horological expertise looms large in Barry's consciousness. Probably no other contemporary American novel features such frequent aesthetic and technical reflections on specific brands of precious vintage and contemporary luxury wristwatches. These are a particularly apt symbol in representing Barry's identity, as they embody the

[32]Ibid., 187.
[33]Miller, *Death of a Salesman*, 44. Miller's canonical play substantiates the harshest critique of the American business world in the twentieth century.
[34]Shteyngart, *Lake*, 159–60.
[35]Ibid., 224.
[36]Bryla, "Rewriting the American Dream," 157.
[37]Naydan, "Politics of Genre Migration," 366.
[38]Shteyngart, *Lake*, 129.

precision of time-keeping in contemporary global financial practices[39] – scheduled trading of shares; global markets opening and closing hours; interconnected stock exchanges in "real-time" – while they can be universally recognised as a status symbol for the rich global elites. Barry frequently assesses people's personalities through the watches they wear and negotiates his own changing moods by observing the one he is wearing.[40] Further, his fetishising of watches involves an admiration for engineering, craftsmanship and beauty, even leading him to perceive in them "the appearance of… a soul"[41] while, conversely, he can envision the autistic Shiva as a "malfunctioning [child]"[42] in machinistic, posthuman terms.

The ending of *Lake Success* deserves attention in how it foregrounds Shteyngart's critique of contemporary America through his investor protagonist. In a National Public Radio interview in 2018, the writer owned to "the deep 'stakes' of the political subject in *Lake Success* … want[ing] his readers to understand how we 'got to where we are as a country.'"[43] Barry avoids prison for an "insider trading" scandal by settling 4.5 million dollars with the SEC[44] authority; the divorce alimony from Seema is also settled at a large sum through expert legal counselling. And, phoenix-like, Barry has enough wealth left to set up two further hedge funds – Last Tycoon and Balance Wheel capital – which fail in succession, but still manages to "[come] away with another thirty million […] Barry was good at making and losing money and getting paid for both handsomely".[45] With these massive profits, he turns to professional watch collecting, bidding large sums at Christie's auctioneers and setting up a private "Watcharium" lined with glass cases, only to feel deeply disgusted after his most expensive purchase:

> The problem with the 7.2 million-dollar [Bao Dai] Rolex[46] was that it was one of the ugliest watches he had ever seen. It was made of shiny intemperate yellow gold … It was studded with four ridiculous diamond indexes. The last emperor of Vietnam was … a silly man, an "amoral opportunist", […] who had squandered part of his nation's patrimony on things like this pointless watch.[47]

Barry's narcissism reaches a crisis here, in his realisation that extreme wealth and the totemic objects which represent it are ugly, in more senses than one. The last emperor of Vietnam in the wake of World War II, known as the Bao Dai, was a puppet figure of the French Protectorate usually exiled in France and Monaco, pursuing extravagant leisure and earning the nicknames "playboy" and "night-club" emperor as a relentless womaniser. Shteyngart's evocation of the Bao Dai inevitably resonates, in 2018 America, with Donald Trump as a divisive president with no political expertise, dubious business practices, and a crudely mysognistic outlook. As Naydan notes, "Shteyngart charts the course

[39]In historical terms, the background to this discussion is more extensive and complex. Precise timekeeping is at the roots of modern industrial capitalism (working hours, working days) while the notion of "linear time" relates to a Marxist (later Benjaminian) critique of capitalist political economy, led by a bourgeois ruling class, set on "measurement" and "comparison." Clocks and other acoustic time signals are the earliest methods of exercising institutional power, social control, and surveillance (church and school bells, factory sirens).
[40]Shteyngart, *Lake,* 11, 42, 63, 118, 139.
[41]Ibid., 43.
[42]Ibid., 111.
[43]Naydan, "Politics of Genre Migration," 369.
[44]The U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission.
[45]Shteyngart, *Lake*, 318.
[46]Shteyngart mostly draws from facts. See Naas, "Bao Dai Rolex Sells."
[47]Shteyngart, *Lake*, 322–3.

of Barry's life ... in order to invite Americans to consider the way in which individual trajectories shape the national one."[48] Like that of Donald Trump and the Bao Dai, Barry's narcissism has been defined by his innate skills at making money, favoured by market deregulation in the United States and capitalist practices globally, and his tendency to commodify others, whether in terms of gender, race, class or disability. Yet his last selfless actions suggestively point to a certain deliverance from narcissism and self-centredness. Barry eventually sells his entire watch collection and attends his son Shiva's bar-mitzvah, signalling also towards a reconciliation with his wife. As a gift for the child, he stays up all night, laborously restoring his one remaining watch, a vintage and superbly engineered 1940s "Universal Genève Tri-Compax", a watch that, significantly, predates the era of globalisation and neoliberalism. By performing this task, Barry ultimately resignifies his love of watches in the ethical terms of the Jewish *macher* (handyman) whose labour of love signals an eventual acceptance of the autistic son he has so far failed to father: in the words of Miller's character Linda Loman, he finally "pays attention" and awakens to human frailty and compassion.

3. Forever Consumers, Consumers (of) Forever: *Super Sad True Love Story*

Shteyngart's dystopian, yet uncannily familiar, *Super Sad True Love Story* is probably his most read work and the one that has spurred a wider array of critical approaches. Geoff Hamilton has listed responses to this text across fields as diverse as Economics, Media Studies, Biology and Aging Studies, Dystopian studies, and even Psychiatry, a diversity the critic reads as attesting "to [the novel's] broad cultural relevance".[49]

Overtly invoking the excesses of free market economy, the dominance of transglobal corporations, and the subservience of digital network technologies to both, the ill-fated lovers Lenny Abraham and Eunice Park live in a near-future United States provisionally governed by the American Restoration Authority, or ARA, which publicly ranks citizens on the basis of their individual "Credit", with capital C. The country is beyond financial collapse, and uses the "Yuan-pegged dollar" as investment currency, after China has become its main creditor and large corporations have become capitalised by the powerful Chinese economy.[50] As it awaits the visit of the Chinese Central Banker, the US has gone beyond Zygmunt Bauman's notion of the "weak, quasi-state ... reduced to the (useful) role of local police precinct, securing a modicum of order required for [conducting] business but not to be feared as effective brake[s] on the global companies' freedom".[51]

Conveniently for the control of American citizens' wealth by the ARA, a not too distant technology has developed the "äppärät", a ubiquitous gadget that exceeds the functions of an I-Phone, as it streams figures continuously onto "Credit Poles" on the sidewalks and connects to other "äpärätti" users, publicly reporting each individual's "worth" or Credit ranking. Lenny works for a bioengineering company providing (and named) "Indefinite Life" Extension, something that only "High Net Worth Individuals"

[48]Naydan, "Politics of Genre Migration," 369.
[49]Hamilton, *Understanding Gary Shteyngart*, 61.
[50]Although dystopian for the US, countries that resort to a dual economy or foreign robust currencies are recognisable in the Americas, notably Cuba with its two types of *pesos* and, more recently, the dollarised economy proposed by president Milei for Argentina.
[51]Bauman, *Globalization*, 68.

(or HNWIs) can afford. In the wake of classic dystopian fiction,[52] Shteyngart draws on the use of acronyms, socioeconomic taxonomies, and the reduction and distortion of language to represent the demands of a hyperbolic variety of contemporary global capitalism, fixated only on consumerism, physical appearance, biological markers and a sexualised youth fetish. As Simon Willmetts has noted, however, *Super Sad True Love Story* departs from twentieth century dystopias in its fluid nature:

> rather than solidify[ing] class distinction and identity, surveillance [here] is fundamentally destabilizing, subjecting the individual to continuous transformation ... identity [is] always an 'unfulfilled project' in which the individual is in a permanent state of becoming.[53]

Technologically-enabled surveillance capitalism does in fact shape all social relations and relationships in the novel, by fostering solipsistic and narcissistic attitudes which rely on the commodification of oneself and others. The gadgets not only report and reveal citizens' wealth rankings, they also serve to market a commodified digital self: while the former function may be still, so far, dystopian, the latter is a recognisable practice in the contemporary exposure of influencers and the so-called instacelebrities.

To provide a sense of perspective and contrast, Shteyngart draws from the generational gap between Lenny, aged 39, as preserver of intellectual and humanist values, and Eunice Park, 24, a graduate in "Images", composing chapters with alternating textual registers: Lenny's handwritten diaries and Eunice Park's *GlobalTeens* account, the worldwide social network where everybody can be found, and consequently, also surveilled or impersonated. As an instrument and agent of global surveillance capitalism, *GlobalTeens* scorns language in its implicit potential for reflection and abstraction, in favour of images, publicising 'super-hints' like "*Switch to Images today! Less words = more fun!!!*"[54] among its users. Eunice uses her äppärät constantly, either to text her best friend to or look up women's fashion from online brands like *Onionskin*, *TotalSurrender*, or *AssLuxury*, which make the sexualisation and commodification of women's bodies textually explicit.

The notion that any human way of life may be mediated and commodified by the dictates of contemporary gadget-addicted culture becomes evident in a bar scene where younger workmates, men of Eunice's generation, initiate Lenny into the FACing app. Although Lenny mishears "fuck",[55] "FAC" means "Form a Community" and involves exchanging personal data, including purchases, Credit rankings, biological parameters, with the surrounding women users in order to rate his "desirability". As a 39-year-old recent buyer of books – "bound, printed, nonstreaming Media artifact[s]" in the techno-capitalist newspeak of the novel[56] – Lenny comes up last in the ranking. Print culture is not something that millenial women are meant to respect in this dystopian US, although later Eunice is actually fascinated by Lenny's erudition. Further, the bar scene foregrounds how digital social networking actually results in the loss of the presence of the "other", who withdraws into a narcissistic, gadget-mediated expression of the self.

[52]Such as George Orwell's *1984* and Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World*.
[53]Willmetts, "Digital Dystopia," 272.
[54]Shteyngart, *Super Sad*, 27. For further discussions of the functions and significance of written language, print culture and literacy in this novel, see Barr, "America and Books," 311–26; Bullen, "Act Two for America," 231–53 and Martín Urdiales-Shaw, "Welcome to America 2.0," 127–44.
[55]Shteyngart, *Super Sad*, 88.
[56]Ibid., 90.

Decades before internet, in his 1960s piece "The Gadget Lover: Narcissus as Narcosis",[57] Marshall McLuhan discusses individuals' fascination "with any extension of themselves in any material other than themselves" and, in an uncannily prescient vision of today's world, argued that individuals

> embrace such [technological] extensions … into our personal system and undergo the "closure" or displacement of perception that follows automatically. … [T]his continuous embrace of our own technology in daily use puts us in the Narcissus role of subliminal awareness and numbness in relation to these images of ourselves. By continuously embracing technologies, we relate … to them as servo-mechanisms.[58]

In the bar scene, everyone is looking into data streams on their äppäräti, but nobody is physically aware of one another or exchanges a meaningful look. The younger generation's inability to *face* the faces of others can be productively read with Levinas' reflections on intersubjective relations[59] and Rosi Braidotti's notion of the "posthuman relational self" and the radical "decentring of anthropocentrism".[60] When detailed personal data from the Form-A-Community stream tagged "Child Abuse Multimedia" inputs Lenny's gadget from one Annie, he tries to catch her eye in sympathy, "but the words 'Look away quickly, dork,' appear on his äppärät instantly".[61] This scene fully epitomises Byung-Chul Han's conceptualisation of dysfunctional "digital tribes" and the advent of a "communication without community" where there are no listeners, as "the other is in the process of disappearing".[62] Communication no longer *communes* (my italics) but becomes a narcissistic exposure of the self through the channels imposed by digital capitalism, which steer users to self-centred and clichéd responses to consumerism and its images, in actual fact turning individuals themselves into products within this paradigm. In this context, Han goes on to elaborate on the paradoxical nature of the screen:

> Etymologically, a screen [*Schirm*] is a protective barrier … A screen *bans* reality, which becomes an image thus screening us off from it … Because it removes reality's *gaze*, the smartphone is a most efficient tool for screening us [and] the disappearance of the gaze accompanies the narcissization of perception.[63]

In *Super Sad True Love Story*, the other significant articulation of the synchrony between corporate capitalist practices and pathological narcissism involves the purchase and commodification of immortality itself. Shteyngart makes relevant here the classic literary myths of trascending mortality and attaining Faustian knowledge to a globalised society obsessed with physical appearance, fear of aging and an inane idolatry of youth culture.[64] In an era of advanced bioengineering, Larry is "Life Lovers Outreach Coordinator … of the Post-Human Services [at] … Staatling-Wapachung"[65]. In plain English, a global salesman of life extension treatments, sent on field assignments to draw very

[57]Although McLuhan was writing in reference to the mass media of his time, many of his arguments in *Understanding Media: The Extensions of Man* (1964) are singularly pertinent to our digital era.
[58]McLuhan, *Understanding Media*, 46.
[59]See "Ethics and the Face" in *Totality and Infinity*, 213.
[60]Braidotti, *The Posthuman*, 58.
[61]Shteyngart, *Super Sad*, 92.
[62]Han, *Infocracia*, 51–5, my translation.
[63]Han, *The Crisis of Narration*, 46–7.
[64]For an enlightening reading of how male characters in this novel conform to the Jungian archetype of the 'puer aeternus' see Ablanedo, "'Forever Young'," 7–25.
[65]Gary Shteyngart, *Super Sad*, 5.

wealthy clients ("High Net Worth Individuals"). In the beginning, Larry, like his boss Joshie Goldman, is a firm believer in the corporation's vision. His first diary entry reads "Today I've made a major decision: *I am never going to die*",[66] but developing events will gradually lead him to a complete renunciation. As the country gradually slips into civil unrest and his relationship with Eunice becomes threatened by Goldman's exploitative manoeuvres to seduce her away from him, Larry comes to realise how his narcissistic, youthful-looking boss is himself an active agent of a global capitalism that has no use for the non-consumer (the Low Net Worth Individual) while it is capable of commodifying love, sexual attraction and everlasting life through corporate power channels and the social distribution of (non-) knowledge.[67] Towards the novel's end, as the United States is in the process of being taken over by China, Goldman defends this transition into a "*better* America", one managed by foreign investors who will, in his words, "clear out our trophy cities of all the riffraff with no Credit and make them real lifestyle hubs ... [to the profit] of Staatling-Wapachung".[68] Soon Lenny finds his own apartment block, with its elderly neighbours, about to be forcibly evicted for demolition, by a division of the corporation euphemistically branded "Staatling Property Relocation Services." While Staatling is executing such "relocations" – a practice that recalls Nazi ghettoisation in the 1930s – of those dispossessed citizens who embody Zygmunt Bauman's notion of "wasted lives",[69] Goldman actually profits from the developing "Rupture," of which he is an active agent, as a way to approach and seduce Eunice away from Lenny, by offering accommodation for her family and fixing all the resident permits in New York.

Within the parameters of this dystopian tragicomedy, Lenny evolves towards a reconciliation with humanism and ethics, maturing away from Joshie's narcissistic financial elitism, which finally involves "buying off" Eunice and "selling out" America. Yet there is some poetic justice, as Joshie's ultimate, God-like ambition for immortality – like that of the Staatling company High Net Worth clients – will not yield to the apparent omnipotence of science and neoliberalism. In the novel's epilogue, projected further into the future, Lenny has self-exiled in the Tuscan Free State, in the now politically fractured Italian peninsula, suggesting a symbolic reversal of the twentieth-century immigrant Atlantic crossing. He sees his ex-boss one last time, as "whatever was left of Joshie"[70] is flown over by the medical school to lecture on Post-Human Services. Twitching from "the recently discovered Kapasian tremors associated to the reversal of dechronification", Goldman admits, "we were wrong. The antioxidants were a dead end [...] Our genocidal war on free radicals proved more damaging than helpful, hurting cellular metabolism, robbing the body of control".[71] In a language in which human biology reverberates with historical, social and political implications – note the wording "genocidal war on free radicals" – a wasted, dying, Joshie admits defeat before the course of human nature.[72]

[66]Ibid., 3.
[67]Ulrich Beck, *World at Risk*, 125.
[68]Ibid., 257.
[69]Bauman, *Wasted Lives.*
[70]Shteyngart, *Super Sad,* 328.
[71]Ibid., 328–9.
[72]Through Joshie's fate and America's doom, the ending of *Super Sad True Love Story* parallels the Hungarian novel *The Melancholy of Resistance* (László Krasznahorkai, 1989), as both works share "the brilliant ... analogy of the human body as the site of order that by extension reveals how the civic body, too, functions" (Scanlan, *On Garbage*, 52).

4. Success Driven: *Our Country Friends* and the Ways of American Narcissism

Shteyngart's 2021 pandemic novel is a manifest departure from his earlier hyperbolic satires, a work "still funny [as] if befits a pandemic novel, but not slapstick funny".[73] Also unlike his earlier fiction, *Our Country Friends* is composed as a choral multi-perspective narrative, charting the discussions, reflections, arguments and "entanglements" among a middle-aged writer, his family and various friends in a protracted retreat in upstate New York, "offer[ing] real characters who resist simplification".[74] As a work which hybridises genres in significant ways[75] the text is prefaced by the theatrical device of *dramatis personae*, listing the three Russian Jewish Senderovskys (writer husband Sasha, psychiatrist wife Masha, their child Nat), two high-school friends of the writer, the Korean Karen Cho, the Indian Vinod Mehta, along with Sasha's student Dee Cameron, and the wealthy traveller Ed Kim. They are later joined by the Actor, who is ostensibly working with Sasha on a script adaptation of his work. Shteyngart draws from his own life and personal circumstances[76] projecting Sasha as an older, fading version of himself as a writer, while thematically drawing from two world classics, Bocaccio's *The Decameron* and Chekhov's *Uncle Vanya*,[77] in the context of the Covid-19 pandemic raging in New York and urban America.

Headed by Sasha and Masha Senderovsky, who represent a "new wave of gentrification ... of middle-class bohemians moving from increasingly unaffordable cities to the countryside",[78] the novel's cast of characters, with the exception of the ill-fated Vinod Mehta, represent a variety of liberal attitudes, which range from the artistic or intellectual to the entrepreneurial and affluent. Liliana Naydan has perceptively discussed how the novel's "colony of immigrant characters" functions as a "microcosm of twenty-first-century America"[79] in setting this progressive group against the backdrop of local surroundings where WASP / Republican / red-neck residents seem to be the norm.[80] As happens with *Lake Success*, *Our Country Friends* is partly a novel of its particular context, specifically the Trump presidency and its disastrous response to the Covid-19 crisis, or the racial tensions triggered in the wake of the George Floyd murder, in May 2020. However, it is not my priority to read this text politically, but rather to discuss some of its main characters as indicative of the writer's fascination with late capitalist, narcissistic classes in America, a theme (and thread) that follows from his earlier works *Absurdistan*, *Lake Success* and *Super Sad True Love Story*.

[73]Carlin Romano, "The First Covid Comedy."
[74]Ibid.
[75]See Naydan, "The Politics of Genre Migration," 307–24.
[76]The bungalow colony is a magnified fictional recreation of the writer's actual bungalow in Dutchess County, New York, where he often retires to write. See Kaufman, "This Upstate Retreat."
[77]Bocaccio's *The Decameron* (1492) is structured around the telling of many stories by various characters who retreat to an isolated villa outside Florence to flee the Black Death. Chekhov's *Uncle Vanya* (1897) also deals with a country retreat of a retired professor, his young wife and daughter, and several other characters.
[78]Miller, "Gary Shteyngart's New Book."
[79]Liliana Naydan, "The Politics of Genre Migration," 310.
[80]Secondary characters such as workmen, delivery people, or the SUV driver who stalks the premises, are described in the *Dramatis personae* as "Various AMERICAN VILLAGERS". This label humorously invokes classic dramaturgical convention while foregrounding the contrast to the liberal bungalow colonists.

Three of the Senderovsky guests are expressive of contemporary financial success in diverse modes. Ed Kim (labelled "A gentleman" in *dramatis personae*) is a business class globetrotter who thinks of his international contacts as wealthy peers: "similarly situated friends around the world".[81] His brother has bought a vineyard in Hungary, and his mother, whose housemaid has packed Ed's luggage, lives in Gangnam, the most expensive Seoul district.[82] Ed Kim is strongly evocative of Misha Vainberg in *Absurdistan*, as both exemplify "[Slavoj] Žižek's free-floating global elite",[83] men of wealth and taste, free from any income anxieties. While Ed Kim, gentleman, recalls the wealthy turn-of-the-century Jamesian traveller on the grand tour, another of the guests, Karen Cho, signifies Sheytengart's critique of contemporary techno-capitalism, a theme that, as noted above, looms larger in *Super Sad True Love Story*. Karen is a digital guru who has become swiftly rich by developing *Tröö Emotions*, a ragingly popular smartphone app that causes people to fall in love by algorithmically processing a user's picture looking into another user's eyes.[84] Shteyngart cleverly escalates the smartphone narcissism of his dystopian novel into a shared mode, one that goes beyond self-absorption. Whether scientifically "true" or a mere placebo – this remains unresolved – *Tröö Emotions* blends the digital narcissism of the selfie with the commodification of the emotional (loving) self, problematising Jonathan Franzen's notion, originally delivered as a commencement address, that "the world of techno-consumerism is … troubled by real love, and it has no choice but to trouble love in return".[85]

One character remains deliberately unnamed as indicative of mainstream American culture's veneration of celebrity status: the "Actor". In a bungalow colony composed by mostly gentrified immigrants, "the Actor [is] a non-immigrant insider to American culture because of his language, his nationality, and his apparently white race".[86] The attractive Actor becomes the main disruptive force: he stirs everyone's awareness, and the sexual interest of all three women. He is by far the most narcissistic and self-absorbed individual: although his own television career reveals dubious artistic talent, he systematically patronises Sasha and derides his skill as a writer. In discussing the Actor in relation to performativity in this "genre-crossing" novel, Liliana Naydan draws on the writer's NPR interview (Davies, 2021) to observe how this figure, like Barry Cohen in *Lake Success*, "is a commentary on 'how in America we treat celebrities' … [and a] commentary on the elites of the United States".[87]

As the novel's plot unfolds, in its distinctive blend of American cultural commentary and classic Greek tragedy, it is worth remarking that the Actor, through his selfish and self-serving acts, becomes an agent of doom for the characters in the bungalow retreat who are most intellectual and most removed from the late-capitalist success ethic.

[81]Shteyngart, *Friends*, 16.
[82]This district became globally recognised through Korean pop singer's PSY's hit "Gangnam Style" in 2012. See Rogers, "Gangnam Style."
[83]Lee, "Borat, Multiculturalism, 'Mnogonatsional'nost'," 31.
[84]As various critics have noted, Shteyngart invokes and resignifies Puck's love potion in Shakespeare's *A Midsummer Night's Dream*.
[85]Franzen, "Liking is for Cowards."
[86]Naydan, "The Politics of Genre Migration," 313.
[87]Ibid., 313.

Accordingly, his irresponsible actions shape the fates of both Dee Cameron and Vinod Mehta. Videotaped by a stalker, his sexual encounter with Dee on a derelict open-air stage of a children's camp goes viral on internet, becoming rapidly manipulated to discredit her budding career as an essayist through various twisted accusations,[88] as hate posts in social media escalate to blame her for the Actor's infidelity to his (public) fiancée. This event, once it has gone viral, triggers the Actor's furtive flight from the colony at the request of his agent, who calls in to warn: "You are not just a 'person' … You are a responsibility onto this world."[89] The agent's words resonate with superb irony, when on the Actor's unexpected (and unwelcome) return to the bungalow colony weeks later, he now carries the Covid-19 infection that will eventually bring about Vinod Mehta's death.

Within Shteyngart's vision of contemporary American narcissism and corporate capitalism, it is symbolically fitting that Vinod becomes the only victim of the pandemic in *Our Country Friends*. His death signifies his final defeat and his alienation from the narcissistic success drives of entrepreneurial America, which characters like the *Tröö Emotions* guru Karen or the Actor explicitly embody, but which have also been surreptitiously adopted by host Sasha Senderovsky in his writerly ambitions. By American standards, the only "loser" (or failure) of the group, Vinod has been an adjunct professor who later adjusted to becoming a short-order cook. Significantly, he is also the most loyal, selfless, and ethical character, the author of an unpublished novel of youth that was read only by Sasha, on whose judgement Vinod had placed his entire trust years ealier. Sasha's advice then not to take up the manuscript with a publisher was triggered by rivalry, at a time when Sasha still had to prove himself as a writer. Aware of its artistic quality, Sasha has immobilised the typewritten manuscript for years and even lies to Vinod about losing the box, while burying it in the bungalow colony grounds,[90] where it is accidentally unearthed by his daughter Nat. This discovery becomes an epiphanic moment for Karen, who recollects begging the distraught Vinod to let her read the manuscript, as "Sasha [could] be a dick about other people's work":

> Nat had leaned over and peeked in before Karen could close the box. "What does 'Hotel Solitaire' mean?" she asked […] "'By Vinod Mehta,' Nat had read off the cover sheet. "Does he sell a lot of books like daddy used to?"
>
> "I think this is a different kind of book. A private one."[91]

In several ways, textual expressions in *Our Country Friends* are subject to a cancellation that results directly from the pressures exerted by a narcissistic, social-media driven, and ruthlessly competitive society. While Vinod's manuscript had been suppressed by an envious, aspiring Sasha, Dee's essays are perversely decontextualised and scrutinised to accuse her of racism on social media and even Sasha's current script adaptation is

[88]One accusation involves a decontextualisation of a student essay about *Gone With the Wind* to accuse her of racism. Shteyngart targets here the cancel culture online campaigns, which function as a form of counter-narcissism inflicted by the divisiveness and polarisation of social networks. See Gary Shteyngart, *Friends*, 195–7.

[89]Gary Shteyngart, *Friends*, 207.

[90]The burial of the manuscript is a symbolic act that suggests classic examples of censored or suppressed literature, such as Fyodor Dostoevsky's *Notes from the Underground* or Ralph Ellison's *Invisible Man*.

[91]Shteyngart, *Friends*, 101, 102.

derided by the Actor as unworkable, signalling a decline that his own child Nat recognises here. In this regard, the novel recovers the writer's concern with the decline of literacy and print culture that informs *Super Sad True Love Story*.

5. Conclusions

A shrewd observer of how American and first world societies function within a global order regulated by contemporary corporate capitalism, over the past two decades Gary Shteyngart's fiction has consistently paid attention to the narcissistic compulsions with success and wealth in his portrayal of a significant number of characters, who often display impulses in this regard that often reach a pathological extreme. Interestingly, the writer has been able to do this across a stylistically heterogenous body of work, which can be overtly satiric and caricaturesque, but also tragicomic and theatrical, while marshalling literary devices from narrative forms as varied as the romance, the road novel, or the dystopian genre. Indeed, the corporate capitalism of the digital era and its corrupt or dubious practices, underlies the conception of characters like Misha Vainberg in *Absurdistan*, hedge-fund manager and watch expert Barry Cohen in *Lake Success,* Staatling CEO Joshie Goldman in *Super Sad True Love Story* and characters like the digital guru Karen Cho and the anonymous Actor in *Our Country Friends*. Whether against a global or an American backdrop, all these figures in Shteyngart's fiction share a narcissitic compulsion inspired by the pursuit of wealth and material success, through the channels offered by contemporary corporate capitalism, regardless of the consequences of their actions for others.

Although their ethical standards may differ and evolve differently, all these characters become, wittingly or unwittingly, victimisers of others whom they fail to see, and whose needs they fail to recognise or understand, displaying, in different ways and to different degrees, the traits of Freud's pathological narcissist which Lasch noted as symptomatic of modern American society: a craving for admiration, a sense of entitlement and self-importance, a lack of empathy and instrumentalisation of others, along with various beliefs in success fantasies: power and wealth, physical perfection and eternal youth, ideal love or sexual performance.

Pathological narcissism informs characters in all four novels, and is primarily embodied by the ego-driven Misha, Joshie, and the Actor, who become active agents or collaborators in spreading conflict, annihilation or disease, and by Barry Cohen in his lack of empathy and familial commitment. Further to this, other, less intense or explicit forms of narcissism are at play in these texts. The ubiquitous manisfestations of the "digital dystopia"[92] – embodied by the *äppärät*, the *GlobalTeens* network, or the *Troö Emotions* app – enable and enhance the commodification and exploitation of current narcissistic practices by neoliberal elites, such as that practiced by Joshie in *Super Sad True Love Story* or Karen in *Our Country Friends*, who control and manage a "technology of power [which] takes on subtle, supple and smart forms, [escaping] all visibility. Now, the subjugated subject is not even aware of his subjugation".[93] In various ways, including cancel culture, manipulative posting, hate mail, induced insecurity, and fake news

[92]Willmetts, "Digital Dystopia," 272.
[93]Han, *Psychopolitics*, 14.

dissemination, characters like Lennie Abraham, Eunice Parks and Dee Cameron become victims of "the transparency society" designated by Han: their digital exposure online, in itself a (naive) display of narcissism, falls prey to the hostile, also narcissistically-driven, instincts of the contemporary "madding crowd" anonymously typing and texting on smartphones and keyboards.

Beyond the digital, not even Sasha Senderovsky is free from the authorial narcissistic instinct to subdue the potential literary rival by betraying the friend, in his long and conflicted relationship with Vinod Mehta. In the twenty-first century where, as Zygmunt Bauman famously noted in the early days of Shteyngart's career, "liquid modernity has created a new and unprecedented setting for individual life pursuits [where] social forms and institutions no longer have enough time to solidify and cannot serve as frames of reference for human actions",[94] the narcissistic characters that inhabit, and frequently celebrate, our contemporary global neoliberal era, often bear out the maxim guiding Misha Vainberg's gangster father: "By Any Means Necessary."[95]

Ultimately, my discussion of Gary Shteyngart's body of fiction as a whole – regardless of variance in plots, themes and narrative styles – exposes how the writer's novels bear witness to the ongoing crises of liberal democracies in the West, where the seats of power have been increasingly transcended and overruled by unrestrained, highly narcissistic, individualisms assisted by, and in collusion with, corporate wealth. In so doing, his fiction becomes very relevant to our times, echoing the insights of recent and contemporary cultural critics, philosophers and sociologists (Bauman, Beck, Han, Žižek, among others) who have written extensively about world order and world disorders in the twenty-first century. To those readers of Shteyngart, in America or worldwide, who may still believe such a vision is excessive or unwarranted, I bid you to think again: the globally broadcast news footage of Elon Musk and Donald Trump at the Oval Office proclaiming the DOGE in January 2025 should serve as a cautionary tale, one that was all too real.

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[94]Bauman, *Liquid Times*, 1.
[95]Shteyngart, *Absurdistan*, 328, 329, 332.

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